Remote and Hybrid Work Policy

Meridian Holt Group — People Operations

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Remote and Hybrid Work Policy

1. Purpose and Scope

This policy governs how employees of Meridian Holt Group (“the Company”) may work outside of a designated Company office, including fully remote arrangements, hybrid schedules, and temporary work-from-anywhere requests. It applies to all full-time and part-time employees in every department — Engineering, Marketing, Sales, Product, People Operations, Finance, and Legal — regardless of tenure, with the exception of roles explicitly designated as “On-Site Required” in their job descriptions (for example, on-site IT support technicians, facilities staff, and lab technicians in the Hardware Engineering group).

The Company was founded on the belief that great work can happen anywhere, but that belief has to be paired with clear expectations, consistent security practices, and fairness across teams. This document exists so that managers and employees do not have to guess at what is and is not permitted. Where this policy is silent on a specific situation, employees should default to asking their manager and People Operations Business Partner (HRBP) before acting, rather than assuming a precedent applies.

This policy supersedes all prior remote work guidance, including the interim COVID-19 Remote Work Memo (2020–2022) and the Hybrid Pilot Program FAQ circulated in 2023. Any conflicting verbal agreements made prior to this version are void unless documented in writing by an HRBP.

2. Work Location Categories

The Company recognizes three formal work location categories. Every employee’s HR record must reflect one of the following:

2.1 Office-Based

Office-based employees are expected to work from an assigned Company office no fewer than four days per week, unless taking approved PTO, sick leave, or traveling for business. Office-based status is the default for employees on the Facilities, Executive Assistant, and Hardware Lab teams, and for any role where the job posting specifies “Office-Based” as a condition of employment.

2.2 Hybrid

Hybrid employees split time between a Company office and a remote location. The standard hybrid expectation is a minimum of two anchor days per week in the office, coordinated at the team level by each manager. Anchor days exist so that teams retain meaningful in-person collaboration time; managers may increase (but not decrease below the two-day minimum) the anchor requirement based on team needs, provided the increase is communicated at least 30 days in advance and applied consistently to the whole team rather than to individuals.

Hybrid employees who live more than 50 miles from their assigned office may request an

exception to the anchor-day requirement through their HRBP; such exceptions are evaluated case by case and are not guaranteed.

2.3 Fully Remote

Fully remote employees have no in-office attendance requirement and are not assigned a permanent desk. Fully remote status is granted in one of two ways: (a) the role was hired as remote-first, meaning the job requisition explicitly stated “Remote” as the work location, or (b) an existing employee submitted and received approval for a Remote Work Conversion Request (see Section 4). Fully remote employees remain eligible to book a desk at any Company office on a drop-in basis through the Workplace app and are encouraged to visit for quarterly team offsites, which the Company funds under the Travel and Offsite Policy.

3. Eligibility Criteria

Not every role or every employee is eligible for hybrid or fully remote status, and eligibility is not a right — it is a designation tied to role, performance, and business need. The following criteria apply:

1. **Role suitability.** The employee’s day-to-day responsibilities must not require physical presence (e.g., hardware testing, reception, on-site security, in-person client demos held at Company facilities).
2. **Time in role.** New hires, including internal transfers into a new role, must complete a minimum 60-day onboarding period in a hybrid or office-based capacity before requesting fully remote status, so that they build working relationships and institutional knowledge in person. Exceptions require VP-level sign-off.
3. **Performance standing.** Employees must not be on a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) or have an active documented conduct issue at the time of request. An employee who enters a PIP after being approved for remote work does not automatically lose remote status, but the PIP itself may include a temporary return-to-office requirement if the manager and HRBP determine that in-person coaching will materially improve outcomes.
4. **Legal work authorization in the proposed location.** The Company can only employ people in jurisdictions where it is registered to do business or has engaged an Employer of Record. Employees may not relocate to a new country or, in the United States, a new state, without prior written approval from People Operations and Legal, because doing so can create unplanned tax, payroll, and benefits obligations for the Company. Unauthorized relocation is treated as a policy violation and may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination.

4. Requesting Hybrid or Remote Status

Employees who want to change their work location category submit a Remote Work Conversion Request through the HR portal. The request routes automatically to the employee’s manager and HRBP. Managers are asked to respond within 10 business days. A request may be approved, denied, or approved with conditions (for example, “approved for hybrid, re-evaluate for fully remote after Q3”).

Denials must include a written reason. Common, legitimate reasons for denial include: the role requires physical presence for at least part of its core duties; the team is in a formation period where in-person collaboration is judged critical by the manager and their VP; or the requested location is one where the Company lacks legal ability to employ someone (see Section 3.4). Denials may not be based on protected characteristics, and employees who believe a denial was discriminatory should contact People Operations directly.

5. Working Hours, Availability, and Time Zones

Remote and hybrid employees are expected to maintain substantial overlap with their team's core collaboration hours, defined by each department as a 4-to-6-hour daily window during which meetings are scheduled by default. Engineering's core hours are currently 10:00 AM–3:00 PM Pacific; Marketing and Sales core hours are 9:00 AM–2:00 PM Eastern, reflecting the concentration of customers on the East Coast. Employees working from a time zone that creates minimal overlap with their team's core hours should discuss an explicit availability agreement with their manager, documented in the HR portal, so that expectations are clear to both parties and to anyone reviewing the employee's file later.

Outside of core hours, employees are free to structure their day as they see fit, including flexing hours around caregiving responsibilities, medical appointments, or personal preference, so long as deliverables and meeting commitments are met. The Company does not track hours worked for exempt (salaried) employees and does not expect always-on availability; sending messages outside of someone's working hours is acceptable, but there is no expectation of an immediate reply.

6. Equipment, Home Office Setup, and Stipends

Remote and hybrid employees receive a Company laptop and are eligible for the home office stipend described in the separate Hardware and Equipment Stipends policy document. This Remote Work Policy incorporates that stipend policy by reference; employees should consult it for dollar amounts, refresh cycles, and reimbursement procedures rather than assuming figures from this document, since stipend amounts are reviewed and adjusted annually by Finance and may not be current here.

Employees are responsible for maintaining a private, secure, and ergonomically reasonable workspace. "Private" means a space where confidential Company information displayed on screen or discussed on calls cannot be casually observed or overheard by non-employees, including family members, roommates, or people in shared coworking spaces. This is not merely a suggestion — employees who regularly handle customer data, financial information, or unreleased product plans are required to use privacy screens and headsets when working in any shared or public location, per the Information Security Policy.

7. Information Security Requirements for Remote Work

Working outside a Company office does not relax any security obligation; if anything, it raises the bar because the Company has less control over the physical environment. Remote and hybrid employees must:

- Connect to Company systems only from Company-managed devices, or from personal devices enrolled in the mobile device management (MDM) system for the limited set of approved use cases (e.g., reading email on a personal phone).
- Never work from public, unsecured Wi-Fi networks (such as open airport or cafe networks) without the Company VPN active. The VPN client is installed by default on all Company laptops and should never be disabled except during IT-directed troubleshooting.
- Lock their screen any time they step away from their device, including at home, and especially in any shared or public workspace.
- Report a lost or stolen device to IT Security within one hour of discovery, regardless of time of day, using the 24-hour IT Security hotline. Delay in reporting is treated as an aggravating factor if the device is later found to have been compromised.
- Avoid printing confidential documents at home; if printing is unavoidable, documents must be shredded, not placed in household recycling or trash, once no longer needed.

Violations of these requirements are handled under the Information Security Policy and Code of Conduct and can result in disciplinary action independent of any remote work eligibility decision.

8. Working from Coworking Spaces and While Traveling

Employees may work from a coworking space at their own expense; the Company does not currently subsidize coworking memberships except where explicitly negotiated as part of an offer letter. Employees who travel for personal reasons and wish to continue working from a different location than their registered home address may do so for up to 20 consecutive business days per calendar year without additional approval, provided the new location is in the same country as their employment record and normal availability expectations continue to be met. Trips longer than 20 business days, or any international travel while working, require advance notice to the HRBP so that Legal and Payroll can confirm there is no tax or immigration issue; this is for the employee's protection as much as the Company's, since working in some countries even briefly can trigger local tax residency or require a work visa.

9. Performance Management for Remote Employees

Managers are expected to evaluate remote and hybrid employees using the same criteria, cadence, and rating scale used for office-based employees. Location is never an appropriate factor in a performance rating, promotion decision, or compensation decision, and Talent Management periodically audits rating distributions by work-location category to check for unexplained gaps. Managers who are uncertain how to assess the impact or collaboration quality of a remote report should use the guidance in the Manager Handbook's "Evaluating Distributed Contributors" section rather than defaulting to proxies like visible online status or meeting attendance, which are poor substitutes for actual output and impact.

10. Return-to-Office Transitions

The Company reserves the right to change a role's work location category based on evolving business needs — for example, converting a fully remote role to hybrid if the team determines in-person collaboration is needed for a specific initiative. Any such change affecting current employees (as opposed to new hires) will be communicated at least 60 days in advance, will include a documented business rationale, and will go through the employee's HRBP so that individual hardship circumstances (such as a documented disability accommodation, or a written remote-work agreement made as part of an offer letter) can be considered before the change takes effect. Employees who believe a return-to-office decision was applied unevenly across similarly situated peers may escalate to People Operations leadership.

11. International Remote Work

The Company employs staff in a limited number of countries directly and, through Employer of Record partners, in a broader set of countries for specific roles. Employees may not simply "work from" a country where the Company has no legal employment entity or EOR relationship, even temporarily, without Legal's written sign-off, because doing so can expose both the employee and the Company to unplanned tax withholding obligations, permanent establishment risk for the Company, and in some cases immigration violations for the employee personally. A current list of approved countries is maintained by People Operations and updated quarterly; it is not reproduced here because it changes too frequently to keep accurate in a static policy document. Employees should always check the current list before finalizing any international travel-while-working plans.

12. Accommodations

Employees with a documented medical condition or disability who need a modification to standard remote or hybrid expectations — for example, a fully remote arrangement in a role normally classified as hybrid — should contact People Operations to begin an interactive accommodation process under the Company's Reasonable Accommodation Policy. This process is separate from, and not limited by, the general eligibility criteria in Section 3.

13. Policy Review

This policy is reviewed at least annually by People Operations, Legal, and IT Security, and more frequently if regulatory changes in key jurisdictions require it. Substantive changes are communicated to all employees by email at least 30 days before taking effect, except where a change is required immediately for legal compliance or security reasons, in which case it takes effect on notice and is explained to affected employees as soon as practicable.

14. Questions and Exceptions

Any exception to this policy must be approved in writing by both the employee's manager and their HRBP; verbal approvals are not binding and will not be honored in the event of a later dispute. Employees with questions about how this policy applies to their specific situation should reach out to their HRBP directly rather than relying on guidance from peers, since individual circumstances (visa status, accommodation history, role classification) can change how the policy applies.

15. Manager Responsibilities

Managers of hybrid and remote employees carry specific obligations under this policy beyond simply approving or denying conversion requests. A manager is expected to hold regular 1:1s with every direct report regardless of work location, using the same cadence for remote reports as for office-based ones; it is a common and well-documented failure mode for managers to unconsciously deprioritize 1:1 time with employees they see less often, and Talent Management tracks 1:1 cadence data by work-location category specifically to catch this pattern.

Managers are also responsible for ensuring that important decisions and informal information-sharing that naturally happens in an office hallway or over lunch gets deliberately re-created for remote team members. This can mean summarizing hallway conversations in a written follow-up, inviting remote employees into decisions that were shaped informally by in-office colleagues before being finalized, and being conscious that a remote employee who is talked over or spoken past in a hybrid meeting (where some participants are in a room together and one is dialing in) has a materially worse experience than participants in the room. Meeting organizers are expected to default to "all remote" video conferencing etiquette — meaning everyone joins from their own laptop camera, even those sitting in the same room — whenever at least one participant is joining remotely, specifically to avoid this dynamic.

Managers who supervise both office-based and remote or hybrid employees on the same team should periodically self-audit their own patterns: are remote employees getting the same visibility into high-profile projects, the same speaking time in team meetings, and the same access to informal mentorship as office-based peers? People Operations provides a self-audit worksheet for this purpose, available in the Manager Handbook, and expects managers of mixed-location teams to complete it at least twice a year.

16. New Hire Remote Onboarding

New hires who are joining in a fully remote or hybrid capacity from day one receive a modified onboarding experience designed to address the specific challenges of building relationships and

understanding company context without regular in-person exposure. This includes: a shipped welcome kit that arrives before the first day, containing Company-branded items and a printed onboarding guide; a structured 30-60-90 day check-in schedule with both the manager and an assigned onboarding buddy; and, wherever budget and travel logistics allow, a funded trip to a Company office within the first 90 days specifically for relationship-building, distinct from any quarterly offsite travel described elsewhere in this policy.

New managers who are hiring their first fully remote direct report are strongly encouraged, though not required, to complete the “Managing Distributed Teams” training module before the new hire’s start date. Feedback collected from remote new hires in their 90-day survey consistently shows that the single biggest driver of a strong remote onboarding experience is manager preparedness, more than any specific onboarding artifact or process step, which is why this training exists even though it is optional.

17. Communication Norms for Distributed Teams

Because Meridian Holt Group operates as a mixed office/hybrid/remote organization rather than a purely in-person or purely remote one, communication defaults matter more than they would in either extreme. The Company has adopted the following norms, which apply company-wide regardless of team or department:

Written-first, meeting-second. Decisions and updates that can reasonably be communicated in writing (in Slack, in a shared document, or in the project tracker) should be, rather than defaulting to a live meeting. This is not a prohibition on meetings — meetings remain the right tool for discussion, debate, and relationship-building — but it does mean that status updates, FYI announcements, and simple decisions should not routinely consume synchronous time from people across multiple time zones.

Recorded and documented by default. Any meeting where a decision is made should have a written summary posted afterward, regardless of whether every stakeholder was able to attend live. Recurring meetings above a certain size (currently, any meeting with more than eight expected attendees) are expected to be recorded, with the recording made available to anyone who could not attend synchronously.

Response-time expectations are explicit, not assumed. Teams are expected to document their own norms for how quickly a Slack message, an email, or a PR review comment should typically receive a response, and to make sure new team members — especially remote new hires who cannot pick this up by osmosis in a shared office — are told these norms explicitly rather than left to infer them.

18. Frequently Asked Questions

Can I work from a different Company office than the one I’m assigned to, for a short trip? Yes. Employees may work from any Company office on a drop-in basis using the Workplace app to reserve a desk, regardless of their assigned home office, for trips of reasonable duration. This does not change your assigned office of record and does not require HRBP approval unless it extends beyond 20 business days per Section 8.

My team’s anchor days don’t work well for my personal schedule. What are my options? Speak with your manager first; anchor days are set at the team level specifically so managers have flexibility to accommodate individual circumstances where possible, without compromising the team’s overall collaboration goals. If a schedule conflict cannot be resolved at the team level and reflects a longer-term need, your HRBP can help evaluate whether a hybrid exception or an accommodation process is appropriate.

Does this policy apply to contractors and interns? Contractors are governed by the terms of

their individual contracting agreement, which may reference this policy but is controlling where it differs. Interns are treated as hybrid or office-based by default depending on their program cohort, as communicated by the internship program coordinator at the start of the program; interns are not eligible for fully remote status.

What happens if I move without approval? Unapproved relocation, as described in Section 3.4, is treated as a serious policy violation. Employees who have already relocated without approval should disclose this to their HRBP immediately rather than waiting for it to be discovered, since prompt voluntary disclosure is considered a mitigating factor in how the situation is handled, consistent with the general approach to self-reporting described in the Code of Conduct.

19. Scenario Walkthroughs

The following worked examples are provided to help employees and managers apply this policy to situations that come up often in practice. These scenarios are illustrative and do not expand or limit the policy itself; where a real situation differs materially from the facts below, the general principles in Sections 1 through 18 control.

Scenario A — Relocating within the same state. An employee classified as Fully Remote wants to move from one city to another within the same U.S. state, with no change to their tax jurisdiction. Because this does not cross a state or country line, it generally does not require the Legal and Payroll review described in Section 3.4, but the employee should still update their address in the HR system promptly, since it affects tax withholding at the local level in some states and determines which Company office is treated as “home” for occasional in-person events.

Scenario B — A hybrid employee wants to skip anchor days for a month. An employee on a team with two anchor days per week has a family circumstance that will make commuting difficult for the next four weeks. Rather than unilaterally skipping anchor days, the employee should raise this directly with their manager as early as possible; most managers will grant a temporary adjustment for a defined period without escalating to a formal accommodation process, since Section 2.2 gives managers latitude to manage anchor-day logistics at the team level. If the circumstance is expected to be longer-term or relates to a medical condition, the employee may instead want to explore the accommodation process in Section 12.

Scenario C — A manager wants to require five anchor days for a single struggling employee. A manager believes one specific hybrid employee, currently on the standard two-day anchor schedule, would benefit from more in-person time due to performance concerns. Under Section 2.2, anchor-day requirements are set at the team level and applied consistently, not adjusted for one individual; a manager in this situation should instead consider whether a performance improvement plan with an explicit, documented in-person component is the more appropriate tool, in consultation with the HRBP, rather than changing this one employee’s location classification unilaterally.

Scenario D — An employee wants to work from a family member’s home in another country for six weeks over the summer. Because this exceeds the 20 consecutive business day threshold in Section 8 and crosses an international border, it requires advance review by Legal and the HRBP, even though the employee has no intention of changing their permanent residence. The review exists to catch tax residency and immigration issues that can arise from the number of days present in a country, not to question the employee’s underlying plans, and in many cases is approved without difficulty once the relevant facts are confirmed — but it must happen before the trip, not after.

Scenario E — A remote employee feels excluded from decisions made by an office-based team. An employee who is Fully Remote notices that several product decisions seem to get made informally among office-based teammates before being brought to her, after the fact, in a

meeting. This is exactly the dynamic Section 15 asks managers to proactively guard against. The employee should raise this directly with her manager, and the manager should treat it as a signal to audit team communication patterns using the self-audit worksheet referenced in that section, rather than treating it as an isolated complaint.

20. Related Policies

This policy should be read together with several other Company policies that touch on related topics: the Hardware and Equipment Stipends policy, which governs what is issued and reimbursed for home office setup; the Code of Conduct, which governs information security, confidentiality, and professional behavior regardless of work location; the Travel and Offsite Policy, which governs funding for in-person team gatherings; and the Reasonable Accommodation Policy, which governs disability-related modifications to any Company policy, including this one. Where this policy and another Company policy appear to conflict on a specific point, employees should raise the conflict with their HRBP for clarification rather than assuming either document controls.